

Hilton Hotel Fire Escape Staircase, Nairobi, Kenya



SERVICES PROVIDED

Architect

PROJECT TYPE

Restoration

LOCATION

Nairobi CBD, Kenya

STATUS

Completed in 1997

In 1995 the Nairobi Hilton Hotel embarked on a substantial upgrade and refurbishment. The 19 floored hotel had been designed with one staircase and no alternative means of escape which posed a huge risk. The brief was to design and install a fire escape staircase to meet International Fire Regulation Standards, with minimal disruption to the fully operational hotel both spatially and during construction. The client had approached international architects, engineers and a team of local consultants with no feasible solution from them. PLANNING was approached by the project managers and within 3 hours a solution emerged. Two months later, construction commenced on a staircase that is circular externally, but square in plan to fully comply with International fire escape regulations.

An addition of a staircase internally was ruled out by PLANNING as we realized that this would eliminate at least one bedroom per floor and would require reinforced concrete floor slabs to be cut away, an extremely noisy exercise using diamond tipped saws and requiring constant water cooling. Our solution was for an external staircase that would be prefabricated off-site in dry conditions. The staircase would also be self-supporting from floor to floor with loads transferred back into the building's structure so that no additional foundations were needed. This eliminated the potentially massively disruptive process of taking new concrete foundations through the entrance hall and/or through the adjacent ball room.

The external fire escape staircase was completed on budget and on time. It is 100% internationally fire compliant and an elegant improvement to the exterior of this city hotel.